GLASSHOUSE

UNOFFICIALLY OFFICIAL

Nearly six months and two assembly sessions are over since the new Haryana government took over, but the state Congress still seems to be in such shock over its poll defeat that it has yet to elect a legislative leader. The 77-year-old ex-CM, **Bhupinder Singh Hooda,** has been shouldering the responsibility till now, bearing the regular taunts of the ruling BJP, including from CM Nayab Saini, about his "unofficial" status. Following back-to-back defeats in three assembly elections and two Lok Sabha contests, a team of senior Congress leaders—Ashok Gehlot, Partap Singh Bajwa, and Ajay Maken—was sent as observers to the state. Their report is with the party high command but no decision has been taken on the leader of the Opposition. For, the Haryana Congress is a divided house, with Hooda loyalists in one corner and his detractors in another.



Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

INSIDER QUESTION

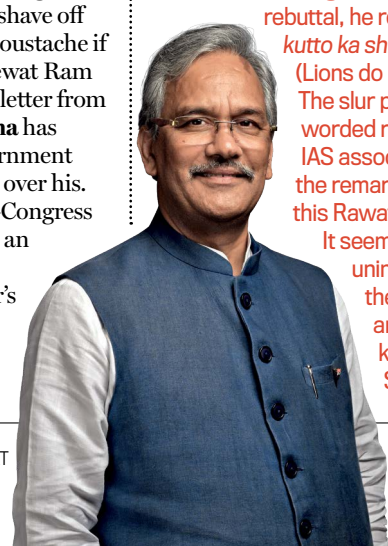




The BJP reclaimed the Khinwsar assembly seat—long dominated by Hanuman Beniwal's Rashtriya Loktantrik Party—in Rajasthan's Jat belt after 20 years in a November 2024 bypoll, helped along by a dramatic vow by health minister Gajendra Singh Khimsar that he'd shave off his Rajput pride moustache if party candidate Rewat Ram Danga lost. Now a letter from Danga to CM **Bhajan Lal Sharma** has surfaced, accusing his own government of favouring Beniwal's demands over his. BJP state vice-president and ex-Congress leader **Jyoti Mirdha** has blamed an "insider" for the leak (hinting at Khimsar). In response, Khimsar's son Dhananjay tweeted that a "female newcomer leader" must learn the BJP's discipline.

Digging up a Storm

Haridwar MP and ex-Uttarakhand CM **Trivendra Singh Rawat** possibly thought he was making a bold point, but he has lit a fuse under his own BJP state government with the illegal mining allegations in the Lok Sabha. The state government tried to douse the flames with a video of mining secretary Brijesh Sant (a Dalit IAS officer) denying Rawat's charges, but the latter isn't backing down. Asked about Sant's rebuttal, he responded, "*Sher kutto ka shikaar nahin karte* (Lions do not hunt dogs)." The slur prompted a strongly worded reply by the state IAS association condemning the remark. But what ignited this Rawat tirade, you ask? It seems babus are the unintended casualty in the tussle between him and current Uttarakhand CM Pushkar Singh Dhami.



RAJWANT RAWAT



Wake up and Smell the...

On March 25, an initiative to introduce MPs to the fruity, floral notes of Araku Coffee turned bitter for all concerned. The launch function at the Parliament complex apparently forgot to invite Araku MP **Gumma Tanuja Rani**. The GI-tagged organic coffee, cultivated by some 150,000 tribal farmers in Andhra Pradesh's Araku Valley, was hailed by Union commerce minister Piyush Goyal as "a tribal treasure", but that didn't quite cut it with the MP who questioned whether she was left out because she was a tribal or a YSRCP member.



Hyperlocal Pitch

BJP MLA **Amit Thaker** (*centre in pix*) from Gujarat's Vejalpur is taking the party's 'Viksit Bharat' mission to new levels. He recently hosted the second edition of a start-up festival tailored for his assembly constituency in Ahmedabad. While many in the BJP were sceptical about replicating such large-scale events at a micro level, praise from CM Bhupendra Patel and Union commerce minister **Piyush Goyal** has turned heads. The event saw some 1,000 local start-ups, and featured pitching sessions, investor meets and mentorship programmes.

Kaushik Deka with Anilesh S. Mahajan, Rohit Parihar, Avaneesh Mishra, Amarnath K. Menon and Jumana Shah